help, least of all the cavalry and artillery Pottinger had desperately requested, saying that all the troops were needed in Kabul. Macnaghten meanwhile said he did not have time to see Pottinger, and mocked his written report: ‘Pottinger writes as if he is about to be invaded by [Mir Masjidi’s] Nijrowees, but I can imagine there is little ground for this alarm and the fellows will sneak into their holes again when they hear that the Ghilzais are quiet again.’[85]

Macnaghten seemed by now doggedly determined not to allow any news, however dire, to ruffle his complacency. This was all the more remarkable as the trouble was clearly spreading to Kabul, where the British were now being openly insulted by shopkeepers in the street, ‘and the whole demeanour of the people’, as Colin Mackenzie noted, ‘was that of anticipated triumph in the destruction of the English’. There were several murders: one trooper was pistolled by an Afghan as he slept in his tent; a private soldier was found in a ditch with his throat cut; Captain Waller was wounded by an assassin, and a swordsman slashed at Dr Metcalfe as he rode from the town to the cantonment. Lady Sale was appalled. ‘The general impression is that the Envoy is trying to deceive himself into an assurance that the country is in a quiescent state,’ she noted in her diary. ‘He has a difficult part to play, without sufficient moral courage to stem the current singly.’[86]

Part of the reason for this obstinacy was that he had just received the news that Lord Auckland had rewarded him for his Afghan labours with the most agreeable post the East India Company could offer a civil servant: the governorship of Bombay, complete with its beautiful Palladian Residence on Malabar Hill. It was therefore in his interests to get out as soon as possible, leaving an impression of a job well done; what followed could then be blamed on any successor. ‘This is an unlooked for honor,’ he wrote ingratiatingly to Lord Auckland, ‘and its coming now is the more welcome when I can conscientiously say that I shall leave this country in a state of tranquillity and rapid progress towards improvement.’[87]

The man who was most likely to be appointed to pick up the reins after Macnaghten’s departure was Alexander Burnes. For months he had being increasingly sidelined by the Envoy, with little to do but to mug up on his favourite authors. ‘This is assuredly one of the idle stages of my life,’ he had written home in August. ‘I do nothing for the public, except giving advice, but as I have no duties to perform, unless it be to receive my 3500